disingenuously, that he would return to his old fief, a decade after abandoning it. The proposal never even reached Sulaiman. Kamran put his foot down at the very thought, declaring that Babur ‘gave Kabul to my mother . . . It is not right [for you] to go to Kabul.’

This apparent non sequitur – Humayun had said nothing about Kabul, after all – was prompted by the fact that Kabul lay en route to Badakhshan, and Kamran may have suspected that, once in Kabul, Humayun wouldn’t leave. Humayun’s reply, in which he argued that Babur had intended his beloved Kabul to remain imperial land, unattached to any one son, only confirmed Kamran’s suspicions. Thus, writes Gulbadan, let Humayun ‘talk as he would, pacifying and conciliating . . . [Kamran] resisted more and more’.

And why should he not? No matter Babur’s sentimental attachment to Kabul, it was Kamran who had ruled that city before and after the late emperor’s death. Why would he allow a potential rival into his realm? Babur might not have encouraged the idea himself; for all his talk about shared ‘imperial’ domains, he had also once quoted this bit of practical verse: ‘Ten darvishes can sleep on one rug, but one climate cannot hold two kings.’[28]

Besides, numbers were on Kamran’s side – he had a ‘large following’, says Gulbadan – and Humayun had to abandon the idea, though not, it seems, before making one last, indecorous attempt to race Kamran for it. Jouher describes how the two brothers met at an intersection near Kushab, some 250 kilometres west of Lahore. One road led north to Kabul, the other south to Multan. ‘Unluckily,’ writes Jouher, ‘the royal party and the followers of Kamran came to the pass at the same time.’

Humayun declared that he should get to go first, being the elder brother, but Kamran would not give way. After some wrangling and a stern lecture on propriety delivered by one of Humayun’s chiefs, Kamran let Humayun and his men march ahead. But now, with Kamran watching hawk-eyed, and Humayun holding on to the vestiges of his dignity, the fallen emperor had little choice except to take the road south, away from the gardens of Kabul into the ‘waterless wilderness’[29] of Sindh.

Humayun’s long exile had begun.

It was fifteen years before Humayun returned to Hindustan; thirteen